



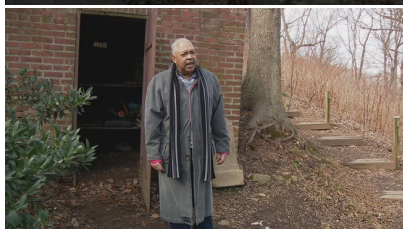
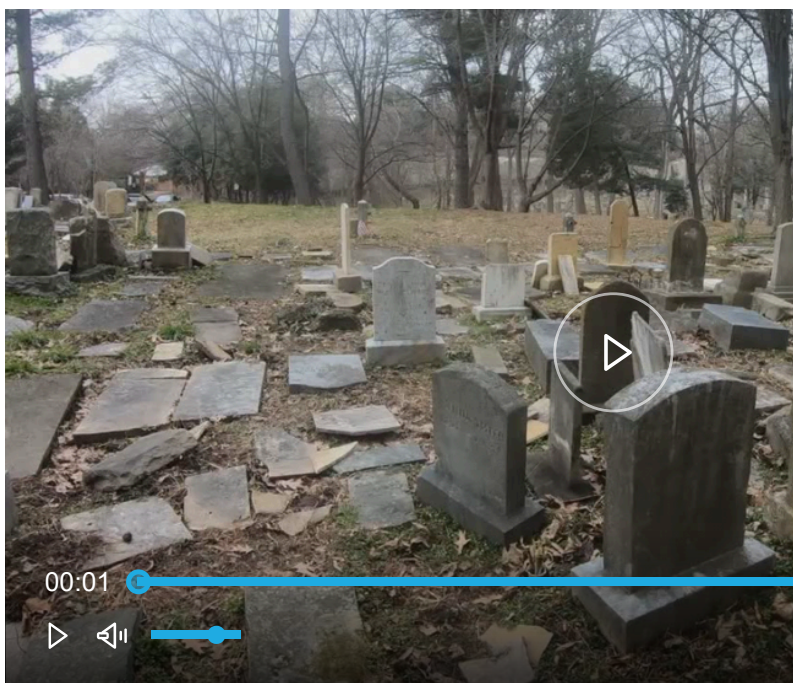
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The push to preserve Georgetown's historic Black Underground Railroad stop

by Sam Ford

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In the 1800s, when members of nearby Mt. Zion Church died during winter and the ground was frozen, bodies in the crypt until the spring thaw. But also kept in there, we're told, were runaway slaves who hid in the crypt. The site is believed to be a stop on the Underground Railroad, and it was never discovered by the whites. (ABC7)



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preserve the history of the Mt. Zion Methodist Church and Family Cemetery, which has a rich history of what a history it has.

Still there, on a hill overlooking D.C.'s Rock Creek Parkway, is a



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But William Still of Philadelphia, called the father of the Underground Railroad, and it was never discovered by the whites.

"Will Still himself documented several people leaving D.C. and heading for the Underground Railroad, and it was never discovered by the whites. (ABC7)"

"Will Still himself documented several people leaving D.C. and heading for the Georgetown cemetery," said Lisa Fagan, who is working to preserve the cemetery's history.

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William Still. (ABC7)

But beyond that significant history, for Neville, it's also about a
Charles Turner is buried here as well as Charles's twin, James L
the bill of sale showing their freedom was bought by the U.S. g
Lincoln when they paid D.C. slaveowners to liberate their slave

" They were, I think, six years old at the time," said Neville. "I be
might have been \$90."





Neville Waters was not yet born when the last burial took place in Georgetown's African American preserve the spot. (ABC7)

Also in the cemetery is a headstone for Martha and Hezikiah T. Neville's great-great-grandparents.

Lisa said they had ground-penetrating radar to examine the cemetery. They estimated that between 8,000 and 10,000 people were buried there, much smaller, in the range of 1,500.

But it doesn't look like most cemeteries do, with upright headstones. Here, headstones are lying flat, scattered in groups. Lisa says that's because they came to reseed the grass in the cemetery, removed the headstones and returned them to their original positions. So, nobody really knows where they are anymore and the place, in many ways, looks more like a park.

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In the 1800s, when members of nearby Mt. Zion Church died during winter and the ground was frozen, their bodies were kept in the crypt until the spring thaw. But also kept in there, we're told, were runaway slaves who were buried in the crypt. The crypt was part of the Underground Railroad, and it was never discovered by the whites. (ABC7)

Even so, Neville calls this a “spiritual place.”

The Georgetown of today is an expensive, exclusive neighborhood. Yet Neville, age 64, is among the few. He still lives on the same street in the same house his grandparents bought in 1927.

“My bedroom is the same room that my father was born and died in. It’s a direct connection,” Neville said.

He admits it’s a struggle trying to create the attractive, historic neighborhood he would like to see. The cemetery has so far avoided removal, even though developers managed to get a judge to sign a mass disinterment order. A preservationist eventually won out, however.

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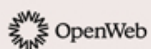
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